PSYCHOLOGICAL/COGNITIVE FALSE BELIEF #44 · ANXIETY

"I have to stay on guard, or I will miss the danger."

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Where it often comes from

Some people learned that if they stopped watching, something bad got through: a parent's mood, a child's safety, a mistake at work, a health scare. Vigilance worked often enough to become a rule. Anxiety then calls rest dangerous. The lie says that the only thing standing between you and harm is your own attention, so you may never come off duty.

What Scripture teaches

Scripture does not despise watchfulness, and it refuses to make you the one who never sleeps. "Your Protector will not slumber." The psalmist lies down and sleeps in peace because the Lord makes him dwell in safety. Anxiety can be cast on God because He cares. Tomorrow is not today's extra shift. Perfect peace is tied to a steadfast mind that trusts, not to a mind that never looks away. You may be careful. You are not the night watchman of the universe.

> *"He will not allow your foot to slip; your Protector will not slumber. Behold, the Protector of Israel will neither slumber nor sleep"* (Psalm 121:3–4).

Also see

> "I will lie down and sleep in peace, for You alone, O LORD, make me dwell in safety" (Psalm 4:8).

> "Cast all your anxiety on Him, because He cares for you" (1 Peter 5:7).

> "Therefore do not worry about tomorrow, for tomorrow will worry about itself. Today has enough trouble of its own" (Matthew 6:34).

> "You will keep in perfect peace the steadfast of mind, because he trusts in You" (Isaiah 26:3).

Common self-statements

- If I stop watching, that is when it will happen.
- Rest is for people whose lives are simpler.
- I have to check one more time.
- Nobody else will notice the danger.
- Sleep is unsafe.
- If I relax, I am failing the people I love.

Common logical errors

- Fortune telling: Believing that the moment you rest is the moment harm arrives.
- Personalization: Making yourself the only one who can prevent every bad outcome.
- All-or-nothing thinking: Either I am fully on guard or I am reckless.
- Emotional reasoning: Feeling uneasy when I stop checking, and calling the unease proof I must check again.

Challenging questions

- What am I afraid will slip through if I stop watching for an hour?
- Who else, including God, is already watching?
- Has more checking actually made me safer, or only more tired?

- What would a responsible person do, short of never resting?
- What does Psalm 121 say about the One who does not slumber?
- What is one check I can skip tonight as a test?

Truth summary

> Staying on guard is not what keeps me safe. God does not slumber, and I am allowed to rest.

Related Pearls topics

Click a topic to open it in the Pearls Scripture Search:

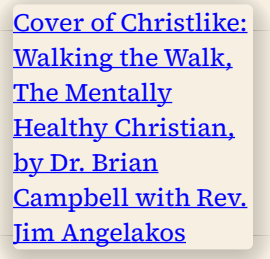
- Anxiety/Worry
- Fear
- Trust
- Sleep Problems
- Peace

Godly Counsel Lessons:

From the book *Godly Counsel* by Dr. Brian Campbell. Click a lesson to open it. You can read it on screen or print it.

- Anxiety/Worry/Fear
- Prayer
- Thinking, Healthy

What does a mentally healthy Christian look like?



From *Christlike: Walking the Walk* by Dr. Brian Campbell. A portrait, verse by verse, of how a mentally healthy Christian thinks, feels, and lives.

Read excerpts from "The Mentally Healthy Christian" (with every Scripture written out)

Listen: Overcoming Anxiety

Overcoming Anxiety · Dr. Brian Campbell · about 18 minutes

Listen: Overcoming Depression

Overcoming Depression · Dr. Brian Campbell · about 20 minutes

Songs that speak truth to this belief

Just Be Held — Casting Crowns
You can be held. You do not have to hold the whole night yourself.

Already There — Casting Crowns
God already sees what you are afraid you will miss.

Oh My Soul — Casting Crowns
A restless soul can be told to hope instead of to keep watch forever.

Blessed Assurance — Larry Ford and Lillie Knauls with Gaither
You belong to Christ. Safety is not something you must manufacture by vigilance.

Each morning ask: "If I truly believed God's truth instead of this lie, what is one step I could take today?"

HOMEWORK · REPLACE AND REHEARSE

My Plan for Replacing "I have to stay on guard, or I will miss the danger."

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Read through each section and check the one that fits you best. If none of them fit, write your own. One choice per section is enough. A truth you choose for yourself will stick better than one handed to you.

Name: _____ Date started: _____

1 How strongly do I believe the lie?

Rate it now so you can see your progress later.

"I have to stay on guard, or I will miss the danger." I believe this _____ % (0 = not at all, 100 = completely)

2 My best question

The one question I will ask myself every time the lie shows up.

- ☐ What am I afraid will slip through if I stop watching for an hour?
- ☐ Who else, including God, is already watching?
- ☐ Has more checking actually made me safer, or only more tired?
- ☐ What would a responsible person do, short of never resting?
- ☐ What does Psalm 121 say about the One who does not slumber?
- ☐ What is one check I can skip tonight as a test?

My own question: _____

3 My replacement truth

The statement I will say to myself instead of the lie.

- ☐ Staying on guard is not what keeps me safe. God does not slumber, and I am allowed to rest.
- ☐ God keeps watch when I sleep.
- ☐ Rest is not the same as carelessness.
- ☐ I can be responsible and still stop scanning.
- ☐ My attention is not the only thing holding life together.
- ☐ I can cast this anxiety on God because He cares.

In my own words: _____

4 My Scripture

The verse that speaks most directly to me. This is the one I will memorize.

- ☐ Psalm 121:3–4
  "He will not allow your foot to slip; your Protector will not slumber. Behold, the Protector of Israel will neither slumber nor sleep."
- ☐ Psalm 4:8
  "I will lie down and sleep in peace, for You alone, O LORD, make me dwell in safety."
- ☐ 1 Peter 5:7
  "Cast all your anxiety on Him, because He cares for you."

A verse I found myself: _____

Practicing the Truth

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5 My practice plan

Everyone does the first four. Then pick one or two extra tools.

EVERYONE DOES THESE

- [ ] Make my Truth Card (below). Carry it and read it at least three times a day.
- [ ] Memorize my Scripture from Step 4.
- [ ] Listen to one song each day from "Songs that speak truth to this belief" on my card, and fill in my song journal (below).
- [ ] Set reminders to silently repeat my truth. Check one or more:
  - ☐ A buzz: my watch or phone vibrates every _____ minutes
  - ☐ An everyday event: every time I _____
  - ☐ A visual reminder: something I will see often, such as a sticky note on my mirror, my truth as the background picture on my phone, or a note on my car dashboard.

PICK ONE OR TWO THAT FIT ME

- [ ] When you could not come off duty: Each day, write down one moment when rest felt dangerous. Write what happened, what you told yourself, and one more accurate statement.
- [ ] My name in Scripture: Write a personal reminder based on my verse and read it aloud. Keep this application separate from the Bible quotation.

  For example, Psalm 121:4 becomes: "Sarah can write: "God does not slumber. I do not have to stay awake for both of us.""
- [ ] Gratitude journal: Each night, write three things I thank God for.
- [ ] Truth recording: Record my own voice reading my Truth Card and verse, and listen in the car or on a walk.
- [ ] Reading: The "Trust" topic in Pearls.
- [ ] Listening: The Overcoming Anxiety audio or the Overcoming Depression audio by Dr. Brian Campbell. Tap to play.

6 My action step this week

Do one thing that tests the lie in real life.

Choose steps you can do safely. If this belief comes with hopelessness or thoughts of ending your life, call or text 988 (the Suicide & Crisis Lifeline), or call 911 in an emergency. You do not have to carry this alone.

- [ ] Skip one extra check. Choose one habitual check that is not truly needed, leave it undone once, and write what happened.
- [ ] Set a watch-ending time. Decide when today's vigilance stops, and do not reopen the worries after that time.
- [ ] Hand the night to God. Read Psalm 4:8 aloud at bedtime for seven nights.
- [ ] Tell one person you are tired of watching and let them carry one concern with you.

What I will do: _____

When: _____

What the lie predicts will happen: _____

7 End-of-week check-in

Bring this page to your next session.

What actually happened: _____

_____

What I learned: _____

The lie “I have to stay on guard, or I will miss the danger.”: _____ % My truth: _____ %

Daily practice tracker

Day	Read my card	Said my verse	Used my reminder	A check I was able to skip
Mon				
Tue				
Wed				
Thu				
Fri				
Sat				
Sun				

My song journal

After each day's song, write what it told you that challenges the lie.

Day	Song I listened to	What it told me that challenges the lie
Mon		
Tue		
Wed		
Thu		
Fri		
Sat		
Sun		

My Truth Card

THE LIE

~~I have to stay on guard, or I will miss the danger~~

THE TRUTH

GOD'S WORD

Copy onto a 3×5 card, or cut along the dashed line and carry it with you.

Prayer

Lord, I have appointed myself the one who never sleeps. You do not slumber. Teach me to rest without calling rest a failure, and to trust You with what I cannot watch. Amen.

Scripture quotations are from the Berean Standard Bible (BSB), which is in the public domain.